



Revitalization: global contexts, outcomes, success

Ling 98A Junior Tutorial [Fall 2023]

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**what counts as “success” in
language reclamation?**



success stories

- **US and Canada:** Karuk, Chochenyo (CA), Wopanaak (MA), Hawaiian (HI), Myaamia (IL), Navajo (NM), Inuktitut, Anishinaabemowin (ON), Heiltsuk (BC)
- **western Europe:** Cornish, Welsh, Manx, Scottish Gaelic (UK), Irish (Ireland), Breton (France), Catalan, Basque (Spain), Sami (Norway)
- **Australia and New Zealand:** Maori (NZ), Kaurua, Diyari, Barngarla (AU)
- **other:** Quechua (Peru), Zapotec (Mexico), Nahuatl (El Salvador), Hebrew (Israel), Laz (Turkey), Mandinka (western Africa), Ainu (Japan), Duoxu (China)
- ... and more!



common circumstances

- trends in the communities that have had successful language reclamation:
 - located in western Europe or **white settler colonial states**
 - (related to above) wealthier nations, **English/Spanish speaking**
 - strong **ethnic identity and community**, even if language was dormant
 - **single language** of a state, e.g. Hawaiian, Maori, Hebrew
- what are the reasons behind these trends?



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 - **single language** of a state, e.g. Hawaiian, Maori, Hebrew
- 1) lack of reports on language reclamation from Asia and Africa in western media, 2) financial and institutional resources in the US and Europe as well as their spheres of influence, 3) the rise of indigenous movements predominantly in wealthier nations, 4) relative political, economic, and social stability



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- how do these trends affect what we know about language reclamation?



imbalance in representation



- concepts and methods of reclamation **developed in the western context**, albeit for indigenous and minoritized communities in the western world
 - assumptions of access to resources
- unclear if they would apply to experiences of those in Asia and Africa
 - e.g. attitudes towards language, towards outsiders, etc.
- context-sensitive expansion of language reclamation practice and theory such that it is both **globalized and decolonized** (Roche 2018)

let's look at some examples

Hawaiian (Olelo Hawai'i)

- by mid-20th century, most native Hawaiians spoke Hawai'i Creole English
- Hawaii becomes a state in 1959, influx of wealth and tourism
- youth cultural revolution in 1960s
- state recognition and DOE funding for Punana Leo ("language nest") and Kula Kaiapuni immersion programs
- the number of fluent speakers has risen from 2,000 in 1978 to 24,000 in 2016



‘Ōlelo Hawai‘i

Hebrew (Ivrit)

- became dormant after 200 CE except through liturgy
- strong sense of Jewish identity and shared religion
- emergence of Zionism in 1880s and influx of Jews to Palestine, development of literary and spoken Hebrew
- innovation of new Hebrew words
- the number of fluent speakers has risen from 0 in 18th century to 9 million in 2017; a unique case of success
- sole official language of the state of Israel as of 2018



Teotitlan del Valle Zapotec

- the number of speakers is 3000 in 2010, where over 90% are bilingual in Spanish
- immersion camps with cultural activities, evaluation via self-report and observation
- involvement of children and parents together
- digital tools such as the Online Talking Dictionary (designed by US linguists)
- Zapotec language programming in local radio



**what are some commonalities
in these reclamation efforts?**



common obstacles



- expansion into domains outside of school (in particular the home)
 - lack of **language transmission** across generations
 - stigma or misconceptions towards bilingualism in the home
- lack of **native speakers as teachers** and experts on the language
 - native and fluent speakers are often elders
 - “**missing generation**” of adults who grew up during the period of shift; between elders who are native and youth who are reclaiming the language

common obstacles



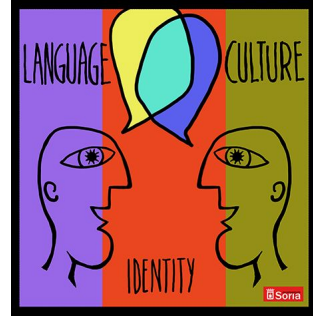
- lack of **funding and curriculum development** for educational programs
 - language resources are often inadequate or do not address needs
 - often dictionaries and grammars are **not very accessible**
- **socioeconomic pressures** to shift, lack of public and community support
 - language learning requires time and resources from each individual, which may not be a priority compared to other concerns
 - internal conflicts due to differing attitudes towards revitalization
- **complex grammar or sound systems** may pose a steep learning curve

- *“The government has spent the last decade pushing purely for language revitalization, but that doesn’t work without the cultural aspects” - Mahung*
- *“I really want to come back to the village after I graduate.. that is my dream.. but I don’t really see how that is feasible” - Temu, student*
- *“They tell us to teach prefixes and suffixes, it is hard for us to understand what those are” - Uma, Seediq language teacher*
- *“The language is really difficult, and I get discouraged!” - Rabe, student*
- *“In [the curriculum] that linguists developed, we need to teach students to use ka [the pivot marker], but if the elders don’t even use it [in conversational speech], should we really be teaching it that way?” - Obing, principal*



common paths to success

- combined linguistic and cultural activism
 - community engagement and local grassroots driven efforts
- knowledge of shared history and identity, sense of pride and belonging
- language use in **multiple domains**, e.g. school, home, entertainment, etc.
 - incorporating **new technology**, allowing new words and language change
 - adequate documentation and **accessible language materials**
- official state/government recognition and institutional funding



revitalization projects

- [website](#) for language and cultural resources
- local [radio stations](#) for outreach
- user friendly and pedagogical [dictionary](#)
- language [media](#) and entertainment
- culturally relevant [language pedagogy](#)
- active [social media](#) engagement



teaching approach

- language teaching can look very different depending on the language's status: foreign, major, heritage, etc.
- must be mindful of the influence of learners on the language, especially if there are few native speakers

teaching languages of different status (Hinton 2011) ->

	Foreign languages	Majority languages	Heritage languages	Endangered languages
1. Primary goal of the program	Helping people gain knowledge of language and culture of another society	Helping people function in the dominant language of the society	Helping people gain ability in their ancestral tongue	Save language from extinction; bring it back into use
2. Learner's motives	Communication with foreigners or immigrants at home or abroad; develop literary knowledge of another language	Acquire a sense of membership in the dominant culture; gain economic power	Ability to speak to older relatives; retain or regain ties to one's home country; belonging to a minority culture; political stance about cultural and linguistic autonomy	Sense of identity, belonging to a minority culture; resistance to assimilation; political stance about cultural and linguistic autonomy; spiritual and cultural access
3. Expected future relationship of the learner to the language	Tourist, teacher, job where the language is used	Linguistic assimilation to the dominant society	Speaking or writing to friends and relatives; visits and other ties to one's country of origin	Become a language activist and a transmitter of the language to future generations (through teaching, parenthood); help form a language community
4. Possible influence on the language being learned	None	None (or New Englishes)	None on the language as spoken in the home country; possible establishment of a new dialect in the new country	Influence of a dominant language (e.g. English) on the endangered language; modernization of the endangered language
5. Considerations for teaching	Big literature on language teaching, lots of research, lots of available tools and materials	Big literature on language teaching, lots of research, lots of available tools and materials	Development of heritage learner courses to accommodate differences in learning needs	Evolving strategies, including 'bootstrap' methods

teaching methods



- depends on size of community, resources, time, and interest
- **language immersion schools** (e.g. Hawaiian) are highly successful, but require larger communities and control of educational curriculum
- **language classes** and **language camps** (e.g. Zapotec) are more feasible in smaller communities and communities without government support
- **intensive language programs** (e.g. Karuk) are particularly useful for training adults that can themselves go on to train and teach others
- **parent training programs** (e.g. Scottish Gaelic) are aimed at the domain of the home with the goal of improving intergenerational transmission

progress and evaluation



- how does one evaluate the effectiveness of language programs?
- while evaluation and metrics can be political and problematic, when done well it is an important tool to assess where to direct resources and attention
 - limited time and resources, align goals and manage expectations
- **democratic evaluation** (House & Howe 2000):
 - a combination of the following: semi-structured interviews that allow for self-report progress and feedback, focus group with parents, observations in the classroom and of natural speech between peers



goals: immediate vs. long-term

- immediate goals:
 - reinforcing relationships between native speakers (often elders or adults in general) and the children in the community
 - give students contexts and spaces for practicing language
 - destigmatize use of the language and create positive associations
 - encourage students to lean into the learning process, which includes not being fluent, making mistakes, and being patient with progress
- long term goals are perhaps more straightforward: use in all domains, intergenerational transmission, active community and culture

outcomes

- there are many different types of outcomes and many different types of success!
- as long community goals are heard, prioritized, and met





role of a linguist

- what responsibility do linguists have towards revitalization?
 - what is within their reasonable skill set?
 - how much can academic take on larger systemic issues?
- **listen to community goals and have them drive the decision making**
 - start small and collaborate, gain experience and be open minded
 - bring in others who can contribute other skills and/or resources



working with language communities

- **it takes time to build trust and relationships**
 - when starting to work with a community, a lot of time is spent getting to know people and their culture, before any real “work” happens
- **it can be emotional in a lot of different ways**
 - it is not constructive to put too much pressure on anybody involved
- **remember to protect yourself too**
 - you should first and foremost be respectful of cultural customs, but you should also know your limits and respectfully draw boundaries

activity: Kipp (2000)

**Encouragement,
Guidance,
Insights,
and Lessons
Learned
for Native
Language
Activists
Developing
Their Own
Tribal Language
Programs**

*Darrell R. Kipp
Co-Founder of the Piegan Institute of
the Blackfeet Nation in conversation
with twelve visiting Native American
Language Activists*

